travelled, soldiering uncle. That's where the influence came from – not from my father. No, definitely not from my father.

Honestly, my father wasn't so much against cricket as a sport. He was angry with me for hoping to play cricket as a profession, making it a long-term career – not as some sort of pastime. I remember the scolding and beatings I got from him because of my obsession with the game.

I guess it's understandable. I mean, him working hard and sending us to school, and me bunking school – private school, that too – and playing cricket wasn't exactly a good deal for him. To be honest, I'm pretty sure I deserved the beatings, at least from his perspective. But that didn't mean that I gave up the sport. Pathans are like water. The more you push us, the bigger the splash we make.

In Federal 'B' Area, my local club was Shadab Sports. At the time, Shadab was one of Karachi's finest. It housed some of the best first-class cricketers in a city that's at par with Lahore in producing the finest cricketing talent for Pakistan. Unlike today, back in the day, even the stars of first-class and club cricket commanded respect. And those guys got appreciation too.

I'm not exaggerating when I say that at the time, the value of a first-class cricketer was more than that of any international Pakistan player. In the neighbourhoods and clubs, people knew first-class players by name. They had street cred and were local legends. People would line up to see them play in their neighbourhoods, even if for a casual game. They were the gods of the homegrown cricket circuit. At Shadab, Haroon Rasheed and his brother, Mohtashim Rasheed – who eventually became the national women's team's coach – would watch me in action.

Although a melting pot for cricket lovers in the neighbourhood, Shadab Sports wasn't much of a club when it came to facilities. Before the matches, we had to turn up with a broom and clean the pitch ourselves. Then around 2 p.m. we would start the nets.

They say there are two types of climate in Karachi: hot and very hot. For me, though, it was all the same. I remember it always being hot. Perhaps because I was a fast bowler in those days, I remember really feeling the heat. During the peak of summer, and especially during Ramadan, the matches would be moved to the night shift. Streets would become cricketing bazaars. Electricians would be hired to set up and take off the naked T-bulbs, set up via illegal 'kunda' connections to light up roads, alleys, even empty plots and garbage dumps. They say that in Karachi's blazing summers, only cricketers and thugs stay up at night.

Despite my chucking, or *wutta* – meaning 'throwing a stone' – as they call it in Pakistan, I continued with pace bowling. No coach or senior ever bothered fixing my bowling action. Pakistan's cricket clubs aren't exactly known for their coaching acumen – the talent of the players possibly makes up for it. I remember what brought an end to my pace bowling stint. One day, in the nets, a ball I bowled hit a batsman younger to me in the chest. He was almost knocked out and was barely breathing. That's when Mohtashim Rasheed, who was watching us, came to me and told me to stop *wutta* pace and try some proper spin, otherwise the kid would get hurt again. I didn't take his suggestion personally and just followed his advice. I was young, around twelve or thirteen years old, and needed the directive. I apologized to the kid and chose a shorter run-up.

I don't know why but in my next delivery, I ran in to bowl in the style and run-up of Abdul Qadir, a popular Pakistani leg-spinner from that era whom I used to watch on TV. Qadir would famously dance up to the crease, left and right and up and down, a waltz of confusion and strategy. As if on cue, I imitated him and threw one in. It was a pretty good ball: quick and a fast